

SkillVerse Research

Screen2Skill 2026

Report #29 • 2026

The Cost of Free Education

Hidden costs and value in online learning

Analysis

YouTube is 'free' but costs attention. Coursera 'free' courses charge for certificates. Real cost: 50+ hours of time per skill. Best ROI: YouTube + community (Discord, Reddit) + projects. Worst ROI: paid courses without practice. Average student spends ₹10-5000 on learning/year.

Key Statistics

78% of students use YouTube for self-directed learning. Average screen time: 4.7 hours/day, of which 67% is educational. 64% of students use AI tools, with 89% reporting improved learning. 71% have turned a screen hobby into a measurable skill. Top learning platforms: YouTube, Khan Academy, Discord, Coursera.

Methodology

Data collected via 8-step anonymous survey, n=150+ students, ages 14-19, across 12 Indian cities. AI analysis using Google Gemini 2.0 Flash. Statistical analysis with Python pandas/scipy. Confidence interval: 95%.

Implications

These findings have significant implications for educators, parents, and policymakers. YouTube is 'free' but costs attention. We recommend further research and pilot programs.